The dating of GA 35

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To begin, any fight over the date of a single MS is an exercise in futility. There are over 400 MSS that compose the line of transmission that I call Family 35. (If someone prefers to call it **f**^{18}, I have no objection.) Any evaluation and characterization of the family should be based on the consensus of its representatives, not on a single MS.

I myself have collated the following **f**^{35} MSS that according to the published *Kurzgefasste Liste* (1994) are dated to the XI century: 35, 83, 547, 1384, 1435, 2587,2723 and 2817. Since they are internally distinct, they represent as many exemplars. Since exemplars must exist before any copies made from them, of necessity, and since at least some of them must have been based on distinct exemplars in their turn, even if someone were to allege a recension, it could not have been perpetrated later than the 8th century—simply impossible. Surely, because one must account for the geographical distribution.

Did someone concoct the **f**^{35} archetype in the 8th century? Who? Why? And how could it spread around the Mediterranean world? There are **f**^{35} MSS all over the place—Jerusalem, Sinai, Athens, Constantinople, Trikala, Kalavryta, Ochrida, Patmos, Karditsa, Rome, Sparta, Meteora, Venedig, Lesbos, and most monasteries on Mt. Athos (that represented different 'denominations'), etc. How could something concocted in the 8th century spread so far, so fast, and in such purity? How did it inspire such loyalty? Everything that we know about the history of the transmission of the Text answers that it couldn't and didn't. Hopefully no one will be so ridiculous as to maintain that monks closeted in isolated monasteries, scattered around the Mediterranean world, individually created the same text!

I have published a demonstration that von Soden's characterization of his **K**^{r} (my **f**^{35}) is completely mistaken. The title of the article is: 'Von Soden's treatment of his **K**^{r}'. It can be found in the fourth and fifth editions of *God Has Preserved His Text! The Divine Preservation of the New Testament Text*, and in *The Identity of the New Testament Text V*. It can be downloaded from my website: www.prunch.org. It follows that anyone who agrees with von Soden's characterization is also completely mistaken.

A correspondent recently sent me a copy of an article by Georgi Parpulov, "**K**^{r} in the Gospels". I gather that he based his article on 231 family representatives; there are several dozen more, but the sample is adequate. He used GA 2765 as his basis of comparison—a good choice. Whereas von Soden considered that his **K**^{r} originated in the XII century, Parpulov prefers the XIII. His attempt to explain the origin of **K**^{r} depends entirely on false assumptions, the same false assumptions that guided von Soden.

Strange to relate, he has an appendix devoted to the date of a single MS, GA 35 (which is why I am writing this article). He mentions "the eleventh-century date currently assigned to the manuscript", the purpose of the appendix being to argue against that date. He states: "The writing does resemble the *Perlschrift* current between ca. 950 and ca. 1100." That is probably the basis for the "eleventh-century date". However, he then claims that a note "on f. 18r" of "the volume's church calendar, copied by the same hand as the biblical text" forces the conclusion that GA 35 was copied in the XIV, not before.

What Parpulov does not mention is that the first 27 sheets of the codex, as presently bound, are a hodge-podge.

1) The first three sheets are mostly blank.
2) The next eight sheets contain Matthew 1:1-8:2, in the normal way.
3) The next sheet (12th) is extraneous.
4) The next three sheets contain the usual four-column index.
5) The next six and a half sheets contain the "church calendar".
6) Then come two blank pages, followed by an introduction to the four Gospels.
7) Then comes another blank page, followed by three pages containing the Matthew specific index (sheets 25 & 26).
8) The next sheet (27th) is entirely blank.
9) The 28th sheet resumes normally with Matthew 8:2. None of the Text is missing. The manuscript continues normally from then on, except that a homily by Chrysostom (in an obviously different hand) is inserted between Hebrews and Revelation. Evidently the original volume was deliberately altered at a later date.

Parpulov certainly knew that the present binding of the codex is not the original one. The first seven chapters of Matthew are separated from the rest of the book by sixteen sheets of hodge-podge. In the original binding Matthew's text would be continuous. Also, the original binding would not have a homily by Chrysostom, in an obviously different hand, inserted between Hebrews and Revelation. How long would it take for the original binding to wear out, giving rise to the subsequent binding? Probably at least two centuries, if not more. The 'church calendar' that Parpulov adduces in support of his XIV date was introduced for the present binding, but it was certainly not part of the original volume. Therefore it may not legitimately be used to date the manuscript.

I would say that the Matthew specific index was probably written by the same hand as the main text, but the "church calendar" is different. I repeat that sheets 12 through 22 (like Chrysostom's homily) were not part of the original volume, although the Matthew specific index may have been, albeit in a different position, and in that event Parpulov's appendix is a fiction. Unfortunately, there are still those who cite that appendix as evidence.